GROUNDWORK COLLABORATIVE

Grounded

Your Interview Self Awareness Toolkit

Know your signals. Build your plan. Walk in steady.

This workbook belongs to

My interview date

A workbook for neurodivergent job seekers

START HERE

How this workbook works

An interview asks you to think clearly while your body feels pressure. You can plan for that. This workbook helps you learn your own signals and choose your own tools. There are no right answers. Your answers only need to work for you.

1 Learn your signals

Parts 1 and 2. Notice how stress shows up in your body and how rooms affect you.

2 Choose your tools

Parts 3 to 5. Pick the breathing, grounding and body language options that fit you.

3 Plan your day

Parts 6 to 8. Build if then plans and a day of checklist. Then fill in your toolkit card.

- Start a few days before your interview.
- Say each tool out loud at least once. Practice makes it available when you are nervous.
- Fold the toolkit card on page 13 into your folio or phone case.

Your interview details

Company

Role

Date and time

How long it will last

Format

- [ ] Phone
- [ ] Video call
- [ ] One way recorded video
- [ ] In person one on one
- [ ] Panel
- [ ] Series of interviews

Where it happens or the video link

Who I will meet

My travel time and parking plan

PART 1

Know your signals

What happens in your brain
Under pressure your amygdala sounds an alarm. Your prefrontal cortex, the part that plans and finds words, gets quieter. That is why your mind can go blank in an interview. Regulation brings your thinking brain back online.

Check the signals you notice

- [ ] Racing heart
- [ ] Tight jaw or shoulders
- [ ] Shaky hands
- [ ] Mind goes blank
- [ ] Fidgeting or pacing
- [ ] I go quiet
- [ ] Shallow breathing
- [ ] Hot face or sweating
- [ ] Stomach tension
- [ ] Racing thoughts
- [ ] Urge to leave
- [ ] I talk too fast

Other signals I notice

Your early warning plan

My first sign that stress is rising

When I notice it I will

My usual stress level before an interview (1 to 10)

The level where I will use a tool (1 to 10)

Remember
Nerves mean this matters. You are prepared and you deserve this interview.

PART 2

Know your sensory needs

Interview spaces can be loud, bright and scented. Learn what bothers you before you arrive. Then decide what you will do about it.

Situation	Bothers me	What I will do
Bright or flickering light Fluorescent lights, glass rooms	☐	
Noise Ringing phones, chatter, open offices	☐	
Strong scents Perfume, cologne, cleaning products	☐	
Clothing texture Waistband, collar, seams, tags	☐	
Temperature A cold room or a warm room	☐	
Crowds and waiting rooms Sitting with other people	☐	
Travel Elevators, public transit, long walks	☐	
A late or distracted interviewer Waiting with no information	☐	

Outfit test
Wear your full interview outfit at home for two hours. Check the waistband, collar and seams. Fix problems before the day.

Date I tested my outfit

Other sensory needs and my plan

Ideas to try: sit facing away from bright light. Wear layers. Pack water. Arrive early so you can choose a seat. Take a quiet minute in your car or the restroom.

PART 3

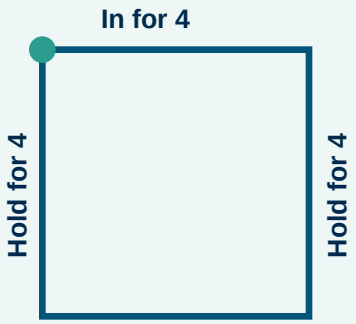
Breathing and grounding

Physiological sigh

1. Notice the anxiety. Tell yourself you are safe.
2. Pause and look around. Close your eyes if that feels comfortable.
3. Breathe in through your nose.
4. Pause. Take a second short breath in through your nose.
5. Breathe out long and slow, like blowing out a candle.
6. Picture yourself calm and answering with ease. Repeat as often as you need.

Use it before you arrive, before an answer and after you leave.

Box breathing



Trace the box with your eyes. Count slowly. Repeat for 4 rounds.

A good option when you want a steady rhythm.

Your breathing plan

What breathing technique will you use before an interview?

Where will you do it? (car, restroom, lobby)

How long will you give yourself?

Practice daily for one week. Check each day you practice.

- [ ] Day 1
- [ ] Day 2
- [ ] Day 3
- [ ] Day 4
- [ ] Day 5
- [ ] Day 6
- [ ] Day 7

Which technique felt best for me, and why?

Grounding: 5 4 3 2 1

Grounding interrupts anxious thinking and anchors you in the present. Practice it now. Look around the room you are in and fill in each line.

5 things I can see

4 things I can touch

3 things I can hear

2 things I can smell

1 thing I can taste

Where I will use it

- [ ] In the parking lot
- [ ] In the lobby
- [ ] Between interviews in a series
- [ ] After public transit
- [ ] In the restroom before I go in
- [ ] While I wait for a video call to start

Other tools to try

- [ ] A calm playlist on the way (headphones off before I enter)
- [ ] Press my palms together
- [ ] Repeat a calming phrase
- [ ] Text a supportive person
- [ ] Slow walk before I arrive
- [ ] Hold a smooth stone in my pocket
- [ ] Quiet time alone in my car
- [ ] Mint or gum (gone before I walk in)

My top two tools are

PART 4

Body language: eye contact

You have options
Eye contact can feel uncomfortable. Pick a plan before the interview and practice it. Looking away to think is normal.

Pick the options you will practice

- [ ] Look at the space between their eyebrows
- [ ] Look at the bridge of their nose
- [ ] Look at their face without meeting their eyes
- [ ] Look away to think, then look back when I speak
- [ ] Hold eye contact for a few seconds, then glance at my notes
- [ ] On video, look at the camera and not at my own image

Video
Put a sticky note by the lens. Set the camera at eye level.

Panel
Start and end each answer looking at the person who asked. Glance at the others in the middle.

What will you do when eye contact feels uncomfortable?

My eye contact plan in one sentence

How I will practice it (with who and when)

Greetings and your body

The handshake

- [ ] Offer a quick handshake and let go
- [ ] Take one slow breath first, then offer my hand
- [ ] Smile, nod and say "Nice to meet you"
- [ ] Carry my folio and greet with a nod
- [ ] Dry my palms in the restroom before I go in
- [ ] Ask "Would you like to shake hands?"

How will you shake hands if you are uncomfortable?

What I will say when I meet someone

Hands and body while you sit

- [ ] Rest my hands on my notebook
- [ ] Use a quiet fidget in my pocket
- [ ] Sit back and take one slow breath
- [ ] Hold a pen
- [ ] Plant both feet on the floor

What will I do with my hands and body?

> **Everyone counts**
> Everyone you meet is part of the impression. Say hello. Thank the person who gives you directions.

PART 5

Pause and Think

Why it works
A short pause gives your brain time to find words. Long silences feel shorter to the interviewer than they feel to you. Speak a little slower than feels natural. It calms your breathing.

Bridge phrases to borrow

- "That is a good question."
- "I am glad you brought that up."
- "Let me think about that for a moment."
- "Could you repeat the question?"
- "Let me make sure I understand. You are asking..."

Your phrases

My bridge phrase 1

My bridge phrase 2

My bridge phrase 3

If I need the question again I will say

- [ ] I will write 2 or 3 keywords from each question on my notepad
- [ ] I said my phrases out loud three times
- [ ] I recorded myself and listened back
- [ ] I practiced with another person

Date I practiced

PART 6

If this happens, I will

Decide now. A plan you made ahead of time is easier to use when your brain is under pressure.

If my mind goes blank, then I will

If my heart starts racing during an answer, then I will

If the room is loud or bright, then I will

If the interviewer is late or distracted, then I will

If I do not understand the question, then I will

If I lose my train of thought, then I will

If I feel overwhelmed and need a moment, then I will

If the technology fails on a video call, then I will

If I make a mistake, then I will

PART 7

Your day of plan: before you walk in

The night before

- [ ] Outfit is clean, pressed and laid out. I tested it for comfort.
- [ ] Route, parking and building entrance checked or test run done
- [ ] Video tech tested: microphone, camera and link
- [ ] Bag packed: notebook or folio, pen, extra resumes and water
- [ ] Showered. Reminders set for deodorant and brushing teeth.

Bedtime

Wake up time

The morning of

- [ ] Ate something with protein and fat
- [ ] Hygiene routine done
- [ ] Outfit on and comfortable

I leave by

My grounding time starts at (add 10 to 20 minutes)

When I arrive

- [ ] Arrive 10 to 15 minutes early and wait in the lobby, not the parking lot
- [ ] Physiological sigh in the car
- [ ] 5 4 3 2 1 before I walk in
- [ ] Phone silenced
- [ ] Say hello to everyone and thank them

During and after the interview

During

- [ ] Pause and Think before I answer
- [ ] Use my eye contact plan
- [ ] Use my handshake plan

My reset tool if I feel overwhelmed

After

- [ ] Physiological sigh before I leave the building
- [ ] Thank you note sent within 24 hours (short and specific)

How I felt before (1 to 10)

During (1 to 10)

After (1 to 10)

What worked

What I would change

One thing I enjoyed about the conversation

My recovery plan for the rest of the day

YOUR TOOLKIT CARD

My interview toolkit

My signals

My breathing tool

My grounding tool

My sensory fix

My eye contact plan

My handshake plan

My bridge phrases

If I feel overwhelmed I will

Nerves mean this matters. You are prepared and you deserve this interview.

Cut along the dotted line. Carry it in your folio or phone case.

YOUR SPACE

Notes

About Groundwork Collaborative

Groundwork Collaborative gives neurodivergent job seekers and the employers who hire them tools and training to compete on a level playing field.